



YOU ARE **16 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

162 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

The baby often brings their hands to their face and sometimes sucks their thumb; but the sucking action is not well coordinated and the thumb is likely to enter the mouth more by luck than design. The arms are now in proportion with the rest of the body.

“Your baby is practicing his breathing movements, which are vital to develop his chest muscles and enable his lungs to grow.”

While they're in the uterus, your baby is practicing their breathing movements, which aids their lung development. When they breathe in, the diaphragm moves downward and the chest wall moves inward.

Each “breath” the baby takes lasts less than a second. Breathing might only happen occasionally at this stage and when it does it can be either regular or irregular.

Your baby might also open their jaw and swallow at the same time as making a breathing movement. A single breathing movement with a large movement of the diaphragm may resemble a sigh.

For the chest wall movements to be effective, there must be an adequate amount of [amniotic fluid](#). This is especially true for the time of lung development (16–26 weeks).

By the 24th week of pregnancy, your baby will spend approximately three hours in a 24-hour period practicing breathing movements, and around eight hours in a 24-hour period in the last eight weeks.

When a pregnant woman smokes, it reduces the number of times her baby practices breathing movements. In a British Medical Journal study, the proportion of time the baby practiced breathing movements was found to fall within five minutes of the mother beginning to smoke her cigarette.

FOCUS ON TWINS

While most unborn twins grow at much the same pace, from now on some don't. Your babies are almost certainly developing all the right organs at the right time, even when there's a size discrepancy. If, however, a scan detects a growth difference between your twins, you'll have additional scans to monitor growth. Doctors aren't usually concerned unless there's a growth difference of more than 15 percent.

ASK A DOCTOR

Why am I beginning to get brown patches on my face? As many as 70 percent of pregnant women find the color of their skin changes. You may notice brown patches appearing on your